

ABSOLUTE B2B

Helping B2B Brands Generate Qualified Pipeline

Why You Lose the Deal Before the RFP Is Even Written

The Case for Winning in the Pre-Awareness Stage of B2B Buying

A White Paper by Absolute B2B

Prepared by Muzaffar Shaikh

[linkedin.com/in/muzaffarshaikhtherealog](https://www.linkedin.com/in/muzaffarshaikhtherealog)

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Publisher	Author	LinkedIn
ABSOLUTE B2B	Muzaffar Shaikh	linkedin.com/in/muzaffarshaikhtherealog

Executive Summary

By the time an RFP lands in a vendor's inbox, the buying committee has usually already formed a strong point of view about which vendors belong on the shortlist — often based entirely on pre-existing brand awareness, content they encountered months earlier, or word of mouth from peers. Vendors who treat the RFP as the starting line are, in most cases, already competing from behind. This paper examines why deals are frequently decided before formal procurement begins, and what that means for how B2B teams should allocate their go-to-market effort.

The Buying Process Buyers Don't Tell You About

Modern B2B buying research consistently shows that buyers complete a substantial share of their evaluation independently before ever contacting a vendor. They read content, ask peers, check review sites, and form a shortlist — frequently before any vendor sales team is aware a purchase process has started. The RFP, when one exists, is often less a genuine open competition than a formalization of a decision that has already substantially taken shape.

This means that a vendor's visibility, credibility, and reputation during the buyer's independent research phase matters more to the final outcome than the quality of the RFP response itself. A brilliant proposal cannot fully compensate for having been invisible during the months the buyer spent forming their opinion.

What Determines Pre-RFP Position

Three factors most heavily influence whether a vendor makes the shortlist before formal procurement begins: category presence (does the buyer already know this vendor exists and what it's known for), peer proof (has the buyer heard positive things from people they trust in similar roles), and content credibility (has the vendor demonstrated real understanding of the buyer's problem through content and thought leadership, rather than only product messaging).

Reallocating Effort Toward the Pre-Awareness Stage

Sales and marketing organizations that recognize this dynamic shift more of their investment toward sustained visibility and credibility-building — long before any specific deal is in motion — rather than concentrating resources entirely on responding well to inbound RFPs. This includes consistent thought leadership, customer proof that circulates organically among peer networks, and category education that positions the vendor as a known, trusted name well before a formal buying process starts.

It also changes how sales teams should treat early conversations. A prospect who reaches out well before they're ready to buy is not a wasted lead — they may be the exact person forming the shortlist a competitor will lose out on later.

Conclusion

Winning the RFP is often a lagging indicator of work that happened much earlier. Vendors who wait for formal buying signals to start building credibility are, by definition, starting the race after it has already begun. The vendors who win consistently are the ones who treated pre-awareness visibility as seriously as they treat proposal writing.

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[linkedin.com/in/muzaffarshaikhtherealog](https://www.linkedin.com/in/muzaffarshaikhtherealog)